

of 1914–18 was what, above all else, the British wished to avoid. It was even argued that the existence of bombers might maintain peace by acting as a deterrent to would-be aggressors through a threat to attack their cities. Since, as British Prime Minister Stanley Baldwin said, “the bomber would always get through,” the outbreak of war would be followed by the immediate destruction of cities – surely a prospect that would deter any country from breaking the peace.

Whereas the British concept of strategic bombing was essentially as a form of

psychological warfare, centered on terrorizing civilians, American air commanders developed a notion of bombing as economic warfare. By precision bombing of factories and transportation systems, the air force would undermine the enemy’s capacity to continue a war. The USAAC was of necessity committed to the accurate bombing of precise targets because its chief function in the eyes of its political paymasters was to defend America’s coasts. In other words, it had to claim to be able to sink ships – small, moving targets.

Bomber prototypes

If strategic bombing was to have any credibility, the American and British air forces needed the aircraft to do the job. They had to have the range to reach distant targets deep within enemy territory, the capacity to carry enough bombs to cause substantial damage, and the speed and firepower to brush aside air defenses – there was no place in either British or American doctrine for the concept of an escort fighter.

The development of bombers was rapid. In 1932, the state-of-the-art machine was the Martin B-10, a twin-engined monoplane with a respectable top speed of around 200mph (320kph). But three years later, the Boeing company came up with the four-engined Model 299, the prototype of the B-17 Flying Fortress. The Model 299 crashed in October 1935, almost aborting the project and threatening

DIVE-BOMBING

IN THE 1930S, DIVE-BOMBERS attracted a lot of interest because they could deliver a bombload with far greater accuracy than normal bombers. This made them especially suitable for attacking ships and close air support of ground troops. Their effectiveness was first demonstrated by American pilots supporting the Nicaraguan government against leftist rebels in the late 1920s. They were then adopted by the US Navy as a key element of the carrier air force.

On a visit to the United States in 1934, Luftwaffe official and air ace Ernst Udet got a chance to fly a US Navy Curtiss Hawk dive-bomber, becoming a vigorous advocate of this novel form of air attack. Udet backed production of the Ju 87 Stuka and insisted that all new German bombers be capable of dive-bombing. But dive-bombers were slower and heavier than other warplanes of similar size because they had to be robust enough to withstand the stresses of a diving attack. This made them too easy a prey for enemy fighters. They were eventually upstaged by high-performance fighter-bombers that could hold their own in air-to-air combat.



WAILING DIVE-BOMBER

The Junkers Ju 87 resembled a bird of prey, with its inverted gull-wing and “jericho trumpet” sirens attached to the landing gear. Its reputation was made during Germany’s successful Blitzkrieg (“lightning war”) campaigns of 1939–41.

The “trousered” landing gear of early models can be seen below.

